

citemsp Package

Per-Key Citation Locators

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Apostolos Tsampodimos*  ¹, Nathaniel Sherrill† ², and Agnese Mariotti‡ ²

¹Center for Physical Sciences and Technology, Saulėtekio 3, 10257 Vilnius, Lithuania

²Institute for Theoretical Physics, Leibniz University Hannover, Appelstraße 2, 30167
Hannover, Germany

Abstract

The `citemsp` package provides a single user-facing command, `\citemsp`, that attaches section (§), paragraph (§), and prefix-based locators directly to numeric citation labels. It works on top of either `biblatex` or `natbib`, auto-detecting which backend is loaded. An extensible prefix registry currently provides ten built-in types, and users can register custom prefixes with `\citemspprefix`. The package parses a slash-delimited syntax, rendering each locator as a superscript/subscript pair on the corresponding citation number, producing output such as $[1_{5}^{§3.2}, 2_{pp.520}^{pp.520}, 3_{eq.4.3}^{§1}]$. Plain entries (no slashes) are batched and passed to the backend's native `\cite`, so range compression (`numeric-comp`, `sort&compress`) works naturally.

*`apostolos.tsampodimos@ftmc.lt`

†`nathaniel.sherrill@itp.uni-hannover.de`

‡`agnese.mariotti@itp.uni-hannover.de`

1 Motivation

The `biblatex` package offers a locator interface through its postnote field. A user can write `\autocite[§3.2]{smith2003}` to append a free-form locator after the citation number. For multi-key citations, `\autocites` accepts per-key pre- and post-notes:

<code>\autocite[§3.2]{smith2003}</code>	$\longrightarrow$	<code>[1, §3.2]</code>
<code>\autocites[§3.2]{smith2003}[¶2]{meyerrochow2003}</code>	$\longrightarrow$	<code>[1, §3.2, 3, ¶2]</code>

This approach has two primary limitations:

1. **Verbose syntax.** Each additional locator requires a full optional-argument pair, both in the source (`\autocites[...]{key}[...]{key}...`) and in the compiled output, where the postnote is typeset as plain bracketed text indistinguishable from the citation number. As the example above shows, the bracket grows linearly with every additional key and locator, quickly cluttering the running text.
2. **No registry, in either backend.** `natbib` and `biblatex` are the two general-purpose citation backends used by nearly all modern LaTeX documents. `natbib`'s postnote is free text with no type system at all. `biblatex` comes closer with a `pagination` field, but it recognizes only a small, localized set of generic types (page, chapter, section, paragraph, verse, line, column), is fixed once per bibliography entry rather than chosen per citation, and excludes scholarly types such as equation, theorem, figure, or lemma.

`citemsp` addresses both limitations directly while working on top of `biblatex` or `natbib`. Locators are rendered as a superscript/subscript pair, visually set apart from the citation number, and every key with its locators is passed in a single comma-separated argument rather than nested optional arguments. Ten built-in prefix types, extensible via `\citemspprefix`, give authors a consistent, per-citation locator registry that neither backend provides on its own.

2 Requirements

- L^AT_EX2e (2020/10/01 or later)
- `biblatex` (any numeric style) **or** `natbib` (with the `numbers` option)
- `graphicx`
- `etoolbox`
- `amssymb` — recommended for best glyph quality ($\triangleq$, $\boxplus$). If not loaded, `citemsp` provides primitive fallback definitions.

3 Installation

3.1 Per-project

Copy `citemsp.sty` into the same directory as your main `.tex` file.

3.2 System-wide (local texmf)

```
TEXMFHOME=$(kpsewhich -var-value=TEXMFHOME)
mkdir -p "$TEXMFHOME/tex/latex/citemsp"
cp citemsp.sty "$TEXMFHOME/tex/latex/citemsp/"
texhash "$TEXMFHOME"
```

The `kpsewhich` command ships with every TeX Live and MacTeX installation, so the above works on Linux, macOS, and Windows alike. Typical resolved paths: `~/texmf` (Linux), `~/Library/texmf` (macOS/MacTeX), and `C:\Users\<name>\texmf` (Windows/TeX Live). Using the `kpsewhich`-derived value keeps a single command portable across all three platforms.

4 Usage

4.1 Loading the package

The package must be loaded *after* the citation backend.

With biblatex:

```
\usepackage[style=numeric, backend=biber]{biblatex}
\addbibresource{refs.bib}
\usepackage{citemsp}
```

With natbib:

```
\usepackage[numbers]{natbib}    % omit if your class loads it
\usepackage{citemsp}
```

Classes that auto-load `natbib` (e.g., `revtex4-2`, `aastex631`) require no explicit `\usepackage{natbib}`. Loading `citemsp` before either backend produces a package error.

4.2 Compiling

The simplest approach is `latexmk -pdf <file>.tex`, which auto-detects whether to run `biber` or `bibtex` and executes as many passes as needed. For manual compilation:

biblatex	<code>pdflatex → biber → pdflatex → pdflatex</code>
natbib	<code>pdflatex → bibtex → pdflatex → pdflatex</code>

Common pitfall: `biblatex` with `backend=biber` requires `biber`, not `bibtex`. Running `bibtex` on a `biber`-based document will silently produce an empty bibliography, because the two programs use incompatible auxiliary-file formats.

4.3 Syntax

The `\citemsp` command accepts a comma-separated list of entries. Each entry has the form `key`, `key/loc1`, or `key/loc1/loc2`. By default, the first slot renders as § (section) and the second as ¶ (paragraph). A single-letter prefix changes the locator type:

<code>\citemsp{key}</code>	$\longrightarrow$	$[1]$
<code>\citemsp{key/section}</code>	$\longrightarrow$	$[1^{\S 6.2}]$
<code>\citemsp{key/section/paragraph}</code>	$\longrightarrow$	$[1^{\S 3}_3]$
<code>\citemsp{key//paragraph}</code>	$\longrightarrow$	$[1_{\P 3}]$
<code>\citemsp{key/section/e4.3}</code>	$\longrightarrow$	$[1^{\S 6.2}_{\text{eq. 4.3}}]$

Note the subscript-only form `key//par`: an empty first slot with a double slash gives a paragraph (or prefixed) subscript without a section superscript.

4.4 Prefix registry

All ten built-in prefixes are listed below, in table 1. Note that no prefix defaults to § (section) in the superscript slot and ¶ (paragraph) in the subscript slot. A prefix is a single letter at the start of a locator slot that selects a symbol:

Prefix	Locator	Render	In super slot	In sub slot	Both slots
A	Appendix	App.	$[1^{\text{App. 2}}]$	$[1_{\text{App. 2}}]$	$[1^{\S 3.2}_{\text{App. 2}}]$
C	Corollary	Cor.	$[1^{\text{Cor. 3}}]$	$[1_{\text{Cor. 3}}]$	$[1^{\S 4.1}_{\text{Cor. 3}}]$
L	Lemma	Lem.	$[1^{\text{Lem. 1}}]$	$[1_{\text{Lem. 1}}]$	$[1^{\S 3.2}_{\text{Lem. 1}}]$
T	Theorem	Th.	$[1^{\text{Th. 4.2}}]$	$[1_{\text{Th. 4.2}}]$	$[1^{\S 6.1}_{\text{Th. 4.2}}]$
d	Definition	$\triangleq$	$[1^{\triangle 5}]$	$[1_{\triangle 5}]$	$[1^{\S 3.2}_{\triangle 5}]$
e	Equation	eq.	$[1^{\text{eq. 4.3}}]$	$[1_{\text{eq. 4.3}}]$	$[1^{\S 6.2}_{\text{eq. 4.3}}]$
f	Figure	fig.	$[1^{\text{fig. 3}}]$	$[1_{\text{fig. 3}}]$	$[1^{\S 6.1}_{\text{fig. 3}}]$
n	Footnote	†	$[3^{\dagger 7}]$	$[3_{\dagger 7}]$	$[3^{\S 1}_{\dagger 7}]$
p	Page	pp.	$[1^{\text{pp. 42}}]$	$[1_{\text{pp. 42}}]$	$[1^{\S 3.2}_{\text{pp. 42}}]$
t	Table	$\boxplus$	$[2^{\boxplus 2}]$	$[2_{\boxplus 2}]$	$[2^{\S 8.4}_{\boxplus 2}]$

Table 1: Built-in prefix registry.

Users can register custom prefixes with `\citemspprefix`. Place the command in the preamble (after `\usepackage{citemsp}`) so it is available throughout the document:

```
\usepackage{citemsp}
\citemspprefix{R}{Rem.}      "R" renders as "Rem."
\citemspprefix{w}{w.}       "w" renders as "w."
```

For example, after registering R for “Remark”: `\citemsp{cox1979/12.4/R3}` $\longrightarrow$ $[4^{\S 12.4}_{\text{Rem. 3}}]$, and after registering w for “widget”: `\citemsp{zongker2006/3/w5}` $\longrightarrow$ $[5^{\S 3}_{\text{w 5}}]$. The prefix letter must not collide with an existing built-in prefix.

4.5 Configuration

Three user-configurable parameters control the citation appearance:

- `\citemspscale` (default 0.35) — controls the locator glyph size via `\scalebox` from `graphicx`.
- `\citemspraiseoffset` (default 1.5pt) — vertical offset applied via `\raisebox` to superscript locators.

- `\citenspfixedfonttrue` — when enabled, the entire `\citensp` output is set in `\textnormal` (upright, medium weight, default family) regardless of the surrounding font context. Disabled by default, meaning citations inherit the surrounding font.

Redefine them after loading:

```
\renewcommand{\citenspscale}{0.4}
\renewcommand{\citenspraiseoffset}{2pt}
\citenspfixedfonttrue           % citations always upright
```

5 Comparison with Standard Biblatex

Standard biblatex	citensp
<code>\autocite[§3.2]{smith2003}</code> → [1, §3.2]	<code>\citensp{smith2003/3.2}</code> → [1 ^{§3.2}]
<code>\autocites[§3.2]{smith2003}</code> <code>[eq.~4.3]{meyerrochow2003}</code> → [1, §3.2][2, eq. 4.3]	<code>\citensp{smith2003/3.2,</code> <code>meyerrochow2003/e4.3}</code> → [1 ^{§3.2} , 3 ^{eq.4.3}]
<code>\autocites[§3.2, ¶5]{smith2003}</code> → [1, §3.2, ¶5]	<code>\citensp{smith2003/3.2/5}</code> → [1 ^{§3.2} _{¶5}]
No built-in typed locator syntax; user must type symbols manually	Built-in prefixes; extensible via <code>\citenspprefix</code>

Table 2: Feature comparison between standard `biblatex` locators and `citensp`.

6 Examples

6.1 Single source with section and paragraph

The lack of randomised controlled trials on parachutes~`\citensp{smith2003/6.1/2}` remains a gap in evidence-based medicine.

Output: The lack of randomised controlled trials on parachutes [1^{§6.1}_{¶2}] remains a gap in evidence-based medicine.

6.2 Superscript-only locator

Chickens were found to prefer beautiful humans~`\citensp{ghirlanda2002/2.3}`, raising questions about peer review in poultry science.

Output: Chickens were found to prefer beautiful humans [6^{§2.3}], raising questions about peer review in poultry science.

6.3 Subscript-only locator

An empty first slot (double slash) gives a subscript without a superscript:

```
\citemsp{smith2003//5}           % paragraph 5, no section
\citemsp{meyerrochow2003//e2.1} % equation 2.1, no section
```

Output: [1₅], [3_{eq.2.1}].

6.4 Multiple sources with mixed locators

```
Writer's block~\citemsp{upper1974, smith2003/4,
  meyerrochow2003/1/2} has been studied from behavioural,
medical, and ornithological perspectives.
```

Output: Writer's block [7, 1^{§4}, 3^{§1}₂] has been studied from behavioural, medical, and ornithological perspectives.

6.5 Plain citation as drop-in replacement

Without slashes, `\citemsp` behaves identically to `\cite`:

```
Elephant dung turns out to be useful
habitat~\citemsp{camposarceiz2009}, which is more than can be
said for most conference proceedings.
```

Output: Elephant dung turns out to be useful habitat [8], which is more than can be said for most conference proceedings.

6.6 Range compression

Plain entries (no slashes) are batched and passed to the backend's native `\cite`, so range compression works automatically when using `numeric-comp` (biblatex) or `sort&compress` (natbib). Entries *with* locators are rendered individually and interleaved with the compressed group. The examples below illustrate different combinations.

1. All plain

```
\citemsp{smith2003, wang2020, meyerrochow2003, upper1974, pennycook2015}
```

Output: [1–3, 7, 9]

2. Plain entries mixed with locator entries:

```
\citemsp{upper1974, smith2003/4.1, smith2003, meyerrochow2003, wang2020}
```

Output: [7, 1^{§4.1}, 1–3]

The plain entries compress into a range while the locator entry renders separately.

3. Mixed entry locators

```
\citemsp{upper1974, pennycook2015/2.3, smith2003,
  meyerrochow2003/e14, wang2020}
```

Output: [7, 9^{§2.3}, 1, 3^{eq.14}, 2]

```
\citemsp{upper1974/1, smith2003/4.1/2,
meyerrochow2003/e14, wang2020/p21}
```

Output: [7^{§1}, 1^{§4.1}₂, 3^{eq.14}, 2^{pp.21}]

```
\citemsp{upper1974, pennycook2015, smith2003/6.1/2,
meyerrochow2003, wang2020, cox1979/12.4/T5}
```

Output: [7, 9, 1^{§6.1}₂, 2, 3, 4^{§12.4}_{Th.5}]

6.7 Equation and figure locators

```
The sloshing dynamics of coffee~\citemsp{mayer2012/3.2/e3.31}
and the critical spill diagram~\citemsp{mayer2012/4.6/f4.1}
explain why your laptop is always sticky.
```

Output: The sloshing dynamics of coffee [10^{§3.2}_{eq.3.31}] and the critical spill diagram [10^{§4.6}_{fig.4.1}] explain why your laptop is always sticky.

6.8 Theorem, lemma, and corollary locators

```
The Cox--Zucker machine~\citemsp{cox1979/12.4/T5} computes
intersection numbers; see Lemma~\citemsp{cox1979/12.3/L2}
and Corollary~\citemsp{cox1979/12.4/C3}.
```

Output: The Cox--Zucker machine [4^{§12.4}_{Th.5}] computes intersection numbers; see Lemma [4^{§12.3}_{Lem.2}] and Corollary [4^{§12.4}_{Cor.3}].

6.9 Definition and page locators

```
The definition of a necrobotic
actuator~\citemsp{yap2022/2.3/d2.1} involves reanimating
dead spiders; see also~\citemsp{yap2022/p37}.
```

Output: The definition of a necrobotic actuator [11^{§2.3}_{2.1}] involves reanimating dead spiders; see also [11^{pp.37}].

6.10 Appendix and footnote locators

```
The theorem that biologists cannot fix a
radio~\citemsp{lazebnik2002/T11} is proven in
Appendix~\citemsp{lazebnik2002/A2}; the apology to
electrical engineers is in
footnote~\citemsp{lazebnik2002/3/n4}.
```

Output: The theorem that biologists cannot fix a radio [12^{Th.11}] is proven in Appendix [12^{App.2}]; the apology to electrical engineers is in footnote [12^{§3}₄].

6.11 Table locator

```
See~\citemsp{smith2003/6.1/2, matthews1995/e6.55,  
  wang2020/8.4/t2, yap2022/p170} for parachutes, toast,  
graphene, and dead spiders respectively.
```

Output: See [$1_{\P2}^{\S6.1}$, $13_{\P2}^{\text{eq.}6.55}$, $2_{\P2}^{\S8.4}$, $11^{\text{pp.}170}$] for parachutes, toast, graphene, and dead spiders respectively.

6.12 Adjacent to inline math

```
The penguin defaecation pressure $P \approx 60\$,  
\mathrm{kPa}$~\citemsp{meyerrochow2003/e14, smith2003/4.3}  
exceeds most expectations.
```

Output: The penguin defaecation pressure $P \approx 60$ kPa [$3^{\text{eq.}14}$, $1^{\S4.3}$] exceeds most expectations.

6.13 Font contexts

The package works correctly in all standard L^AT_EX font contexts. By default, citations inherit the surrounding font shape and weight. For italic and slanted shapes, a small kern is automatically inserted to prevent the locator from colliding with the slanted closing bracket.

Default behaviour (citations inherit surrounding font):

```
Upright: [ $1_{\P2}^{\S6.1}$ ]  
Italic: [ $1_{\P2}^{\S6.1}$ ]  
Slanted: [ $1_{\P2}^{\S6.1}$ ]  
Bold: [ $1_{\P2}^{\S6.1}$ ]  
Bold italic: [ $1_{\P2}^{\S6.1}$ ]  
SMALL CAPS: [ $1_{\P2}^{\S6.1}$ ]  
Emph (italic): [ $1_{\P2}^{\S6.1}$ ] — nested emph (upright): [ $1_{\P2}^{\S6.1}$ ]
```

To force citations into upright, medium-weight, default-family text regardless of context, enable fixed-font mode with `\citemspfixedfonttrue` in the preamble. When active, the entire `\citemsp` output is wrapped in `\textnormal`, so an example *italic* [$1_{\P2}^{\S6.1}$] and **bold** [$1_{\P2}^{\S6.1}$] contexts both produce the same upright citation.

6.14 Font sizes

Locator glyphs scale proportionally at different font sizes:

```
Small: [ $6_{\text{eq.}2.5}^{\S2.3}$ ]  
Normal: [ $6_{\text{eq.}2.5}^{\S2.3}$ ]  
Large: [ $6_{\text{eq.}2.5}^{\S2.3}$ ]
```

7 Natbib Backend

Since v2.2, `citemsp` auto-detects whether `biblatex` or `natbib` is loaded and selects the matching code path. No package option is needed.

7.1 Compatible classes

Many journal classes auto-load `natbib`. With these, simply loading `citemsp` after the class is sufficient:

Class	Backend	Notes
<code>article</code> , <code>report</code> , <code>book</code> , KOMA	either	user's choice
<code>revtex4-2</code> (APS)	<code>natbib</code> (auto)	class loads <code>natbib</code>
<code>aastex631</code> (AAS)	<code>natbib</code> (auto)	class loads <code>natbib</code>
<code>elsarticle</code> (Elsevier)	<code>natbib</code> (manual)	add <code>\usepackage[numbers]{natbib}</code>
IEEEtran <code>natbib</code> mode	<code>natbib</code> (manual)	add <code>\usepackage[numbers]{natbib}</code>

Table 3: Document class compatibility.

7.2 Minimal `natbib` example

```
\documentclass{article}
\usepackage[numbers, sort&compress]{natbib}
\usepackage{citemsp}
\begin{document}
See~\citemsp{key1/3.2/5, key2/e4.1} for details.
\bibliographystyle{unsrt}
\bibliography{refs}
\end{document}
```

On the `natbib` path, `citemsp` uses `\citenum` for the bare number and wraps it in a `\hyperlink` when `hyperref` is loaded. Range compression via `sort&compress` works for plain entries.

8 Implementation

- Backend detection.** At load time, the package checks whether `biblatex` or `natbib` is already loaded. If neither is present, a descriptive error is raised. If both are loaded (itself an error), then `biblatex` is preferred.
- Locator scaling.** `\citemspscale` (default 0.35) controls the size of locator glyphs via `\scalebox` from `graphicx`. `\citemspraiseoffset` (default 1.5pt) sets the vertical offset of superscript locators via `\raisebox`.
- Font shape detection.** The renderer checks `\f@shape` against `it` (italic) and `sl` (slanted). In either case, a small math kern is inserted to prevent the locator from colliding with the slanted final bracket.
- Prefix dispatch.** Each locator value is tested: if its first character matches a registered prefix (via `\csname @citemsp@pfx@... lookup`), the prefix symbol is rendered; otherwise the default § or ¶ is used.
- Citation rendering.** On the `biblatex` path, a custom cite command `\citelinksp` (via `\DeclareCiteCommand`) prints the hyperlinked number and attaches locators. On the `natbib` path, `\citenum` provides the bare number, wrapped in `\hyperlink` when `hyperref` is loaded.
- Entry parsing.** The user-facing `\citemsp` uses `\forcsvlist` (from `etoolbox`) to iterate over comma-separated entries. Each entry is split at forward slashes using a delimited `\def` pattern, extracting the key and up to two locator slots.

7. **Plain-key batching.** Entries without slashes are accumulated into a buffer and flushed via the backend’s native `\cite` (with brackets suppressed), so that range compression (`numeric-comp` or `sort&compress`) works identically to a regular `\cite` call.

9 Limitations

- **revtex4-2 with biblatex.** The combination of `revtex4-2` and `biblatex` is incompatible due to conflicts in `\addtocontents` patching between the two packages. Although not a `citemsp` issue, users should keep that in mind. Make sure to use the `natbib` backend with `revtex`.

10 Conventions

- **Section numbering:** use the source’s native format (e.g., 3.2.1, IV, A.1).
- **Paragraph counting:** count paragraphs from the start of the referenced section; as a manual convention.

Note: Paragraph locators rely on manual counting from the start of the referenced section. Since paragraphs are not explicitly numbered in published sources, these locators may be ambiguous across editions or between readers. When using ¶ locators, consider providing additional context in the surrounding text so the reader can locate the passage independently.

- **Subsection references:** use the full path (e.g., `key/3.2.1`).

11 License

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